

■ By Priya Sahgal with Rohit Parihar

**I**t was from atop the Eiffel Tower that Bhairon Singh Shekhawat threw his hat into the Presidential ring. Six months ago, the vice-president of India, dressed in a natty black bundgallah, climbed all those historical steps in Paris and took a long hard look at the view. Yet what he saw was not the French countryside but perhaps another monument altogether. "Even at this age I could go to the top," he said wryly, when asked if he was planning to scale a politically loftier summit at home.

The 84-year-old has made no secret of his desire to move into Rashtrapati Bhavan. While the Congress spent over a month dithering between the two Patils (at least half a dozen names were discussed, starting with Shivraj and finally zeroing in on Pratibha), the BJP was quite clear about its candidate. Even when the Third Front threw in A.P.J. Abdul Kalam's name, it was not the BJP but Shekhawat himself who withdrew in favour of the current president. In what is fast becoming the dirtiest Presidential election ever, his has been the single act of grace. As Cabinet ministers chided Kalam, the vice-president, already exuding presidential gravitas, issued a statement: "These high offices of the Republic are not for political contention or controversy. These are onerous responsibilities which must be discharged with due seriousness and dignity. I have not been found wanting in this regard for the last 55 years and will not be found wanting." However, once Kalam bowed out, Shekhawat was back in the reckoning. Stepping up the political symbolism, the proud patriarch chose June 25, the 32nd anniversary of the Emergency, to file his nomination amidst cries of "*Hindustan ka ek hi sinh*—Bhairon Singh, Bhairon Singh". The Lion of Rajasthan said nothing, but the smile on his face betrayed how much he was enjoying it all. This will be his last political battle and he is doing his damndest to make it a thriller: "Do I look like someone who leaves the field?"

It is going to be a tough battle for the Thakur, who also happens to be the only candidate who fits the Left's description of the ideal president: one with political stature. Looking dialectically ridiculous, the apparatchiks are rewriting the definition of political stature for the sake of 10 Janpath. The UPA may be well past the halfway mark, but Shekhawat's campaign managers contend it's not simple arithmetic but algebra that is going to swing the race for their candidate. What they are counting on is Shekhawat's equation with political leaders across party lines. As chief minister of Rajasthan, he was local guardian to RJD chief Lalu Yadav's daughters studying in Ajmer; when NCP leader Sharad Pawar turned 61 last year, Shekhawat flew to Mumbai to release a coffee table book in his honour; when he completed four years as chairperson of the Rajya Sabha, it was communist leader Sitaram Yechury who pointed out that his conduct

**IN A POLITICAL CAREER** spanning half a century, the old warhorse is campaigning for a 'conscience vote'.

## B.S. SHEKHAWAT FIGHT OF THE PATRIARCH

**HIS PERFORMANCE AS VICE-PRESIDENT WON HIM LAURELS FROM ALL PARTIES. ARMED WITH HIS CHARM AND STATURE, UNDAUNTED BY THE NUMBERS ON THE OTHER SIDE, THE NDA CANDIDATE IS ENJOYING EVERY BIT OF THE BATTLE.**

DANDEEP SINGH